



MakerCompass

Stop putting your life's work off.

The step before the build. Give it the rough idea, get back the market context, the first version worth building, the scope to hold it to, and where to start.

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Voice · Imagery · Visual world · Touchpoints ·
Applications · Digital · Do & don't

Judgment, not generation.

Maker Compass is the step before the build: it turns a rough idea into the market context, product plan, first-version scope, mockups, and technical direction a serious builder needs before writing code.

PRIMARY SEGMENT

Founders and indie builders carrying one specific idea they have not turned into a real first version. They can already generate code. What they cannot do is decide which version of the idea deserves the next three months.

TRIGGER

Starting feels messy. Tools, prompts, and feature possibilities have created motion without direction.

SECONDARY SEGMENTS

Product-minded operators who need to pressure-test an idea before asking for headcount.

Technical consultants who scope other people's ideas and need the reasoning legible to a client.

THE WEDGE

Everyone else competes on how fast software can be produced. We compete on whether it was worth producing.

ANCHOR PERSONA

Priya, 31

A senior engineer with a side project she has restarted four times. Each restart began with a different framework and ended in the same place: a repo with authentication, a settings page, and no answer to who it is for.

She does not need help writing code and finds "AI builds your app" pitches insulting. She wants to cut the idea down to something she can put in front of ten people in three weeks.

REFERENCE BRANDS — BORROW THIS

Stripe	Measured calm. Dense information without anxiety; documentation treated as a designed product.
Basecamp	Opinionated restraint stated out loud, and a willingness to lose the customers who disagree.
Aesop	Typographic discipline. Warm neutrals doing the work colour usually does.
Field Notes	Paper as the honest medium of thinking. Utility that looks like utility.

Most abandoned projects were never bad ideas.

MISSION

Help builders choose an intentional first version before spending weeks, or asking AI to build the wrong thing.

WHY WE EXIST

They were unscoped ones. Someone had a real problem in view, opened an editor, and started with the parts that were easy to start with: the login screen, the settings page, the framework decision. Months later the repo has everything except an answer to who it is for.

Generation got cheap. That did not make building easier, it made the wrong build faster. You can now produce a plausible application in a weekend without ever deciding what the application is for, and the tooling will cheerfully help you do it. The bottleneck moved from typing to thinking, and almost nothing moved with it.

Maker Compass is the step people skip. Not a finished product. A direction you can defend, before you spend your life on the wrong one.

VALUES

- 01 Direction over momentum

Random features create motion, not progress.
- 02 Judgment over generation

Generation is cheap now. Deciding what to generate is not.
- 03 Respect the idea

A messy idea is meaningful. It belongs to someone's life.
- 04 Show the work

Name the actual output and the next decision. Never sell a feeling.
- 05 Earn the restraint

Every word and pixel justifies itself, including ours.

MESSAGING PILLARS

The start is the hard part.
Builders need a bridge from idea to a clear first build. That gap is the product.

Faster is not always clearer.
Generation should follow product judgment, never replace it.

The first version should be intentional.
The smallest serious proof that the idea deserves more time.

Direction beats momentum theater.
Random features create motion. Motion is not progress.

A bearing, not a compass rose.



A single solid wedge, rotated 32° off vertical, with a notch cut into its tail. The rotation is the whole idea: a direction already chosen rather than a centred needle still deciding. No circle, no cardinal points, no ornament.

The wordmark sets **MakerCompass** as one solid word, **Maker** at weight 800 against **Compass** at weight 500, tracking -0.045em. The weight break carries direction-then-subject hierarchy and survives being flattened to a single colour, which a two-tone wordmark would not. Glyphs are real outlines, so the files carry no font dependency.

 **MakerCompass**

HORIZONTAL • 1.3 CAP

 **MakerCompass**

STACKED • 1.9 CAP

 **MakerCompass**

ON LIGHT

 **MakerCompass**

ON DARK

 **MakerCompass**

ON ACTION RED

 **MakerCompass**

RED ON WARM PAPER

CLEAR SPACE & MINIMUM SIZES

 **MakerCompass**

The dashed field is one cap height on every side. Nothing enters it: not type, not a rule, not a photo edge.

Wordmark

90px wide minimum on screen. Below that the weight break stops reading.

Symbol

16px minimum, using the simplified silhouette export.

Horizontal lockup

140px wide minimum. Below that, drop to the symbol alone rather than shrinking further.

Six ways to break it.

Each of these is a real failure seen in the wild, not a hypothetical. The lockup is generated; if a placement needs a variant that does not exist, the answer is to generate it, never to modify one by hand.



✗ Never stretch or condense. The letterfit is the wordmark.



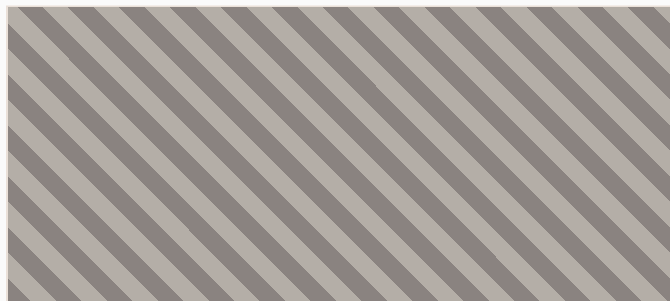
✗ Never rotate. 32° is fixed geometry inside the symbol, not a suggestion.



✗ Never recolour outside the four sanctioned variants.



✗ Never add a drop shadow, glow, or outline.



✗ Never place the mark on a busy field. Find a dark, quiet region.



MakerCompass

✗ Never rebuild the lockup by eye. The symbol is 1.3 cap and the gap is 0.5 cap; regenerate it.

INSTEAD

Need a new colourway?

Generate it. build-symbol.py and build-wordmark.py take a hex and emit every size and lockup at the locked measurements.

Need it smaller than 140px?

Use the symbol alone. It is drawn to hold at 16px; the lockup is not.

Need it over a photograph?

Use the white variant, on a dark quiet region, with a contrast scrim if the region is not reliably dark.

One accent, earned by rarity.

Action Red

#DC2626

RGB 220 38 38

CMYK 0 83 83 14

Commitment moments only. Buttons, the live progress line, active states. Max 10% of a screen.

Workshop Black

#1C1917

RGB 28 25 23

CMYK 0 11 18 89

Body text, dark surfaces, reversed lockups. A warm-shifted black, never #000.

Slate Plum

#4A4040

RGB 74 64 64

CMYK 0 14 14 71

Second-tier text. Also the focus-visible ring: focus is navigation, not commitment.

Warm Paper

#F5F0EB

RGB 245 240 235

CMYK 0 2 4 4

Hovers, secondary surfaces, footer chrome. Warmer than Cloud so layers read.

Cloud

#FAFAFA

RGB 250 250 250

CMYK 0 0 0 2

The global background. Tinted off-white: bright, never sterile.

THE ONE VOICE RULE

Action Red covers at most 10% of any composition. Its rarity is the point. If two unrelated elements are red in one screen, one of them is wrong. Red never appears on errors or focus rings.

CONTRAST

Workshop Black on Cloud is 15.6:1. Action Red on Cloud is 4.8:1: passes AA for large type and fills, but set small text in Workshop Black, never in red. Pure #000 and pure #FFF are forbidden as page grounds.

AUXILIARY & STATUS — PRODUCT-INTERNAL ONLY

- Warm Coral #F4A261

Warm Sand #E9C46A

Warm Ember #D95F3B

Success #22C55E

Info #3B82F6

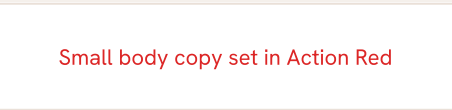
Destructive #C0392B

Never in marketing, on the landing, or in the mark.

NEVER-DO COMBINATIONS



✗ 1.4:1. Two saturated warms cancel each other out.



✗ Fails AA below 18px. Set small text in Workshop Black.



✗ Pure #000 on pure #FFF. Every neutral carries a warm tilt.



✗ Three red asks in one view. Exactly one thing commits.

One family carries the whole hierarchy.

Hanken Grotesk

A single committed sans, from hero display at weight 800 down to body at 400. The range is wide enough to build hierarchy inside one family, which keeps the system from needing a second voice it has not earned.

FIRA MONO – THE METADATA VOICE

Kicker labels, status pills, navigation captions. Not Hanken small caps, not Hanken at a lighter weight.

Display	800	clamp(2.5rem, 6vw, 4.5rem)	0.95	-0.05em	Hero headlines. One per page.
Headline	800	clamp(2rem, 4vw, 3.35rem)	0.98	-0.05em	Section headings, page titles.
Title	700	1.5rem	1.2	-0.02em	Card titles, modal headings.
Body	400	1rem	1.6	normal	Reading text. Cap at 65-75ch.
Label	500	0.6875rem	1.2	0.18em	Fira Mono, uppercase. Metadata only.

THE TIGHT TRACKING RULE

Display and headline tracking is -0.05em, never flat zero. Large type at default tracking reads as a wireframe.

Start with direction

✓ -0.05em

Start with direction

✗ flat zero

Type on dark holds at weight 700 and up.

Below 700, warm-black grounds swallow the strokes. Never set body copy below 14px on a dark surface.

Both families are OFL licensed. Stacks must carry Noto fallbacks so non-Latin strings never render as tofu.

TYPE ON COLOUR

Start with direction

White only. Never Workshop Black on red.

Start with direction

Weight 700 and up. Below that the ground swallows it.

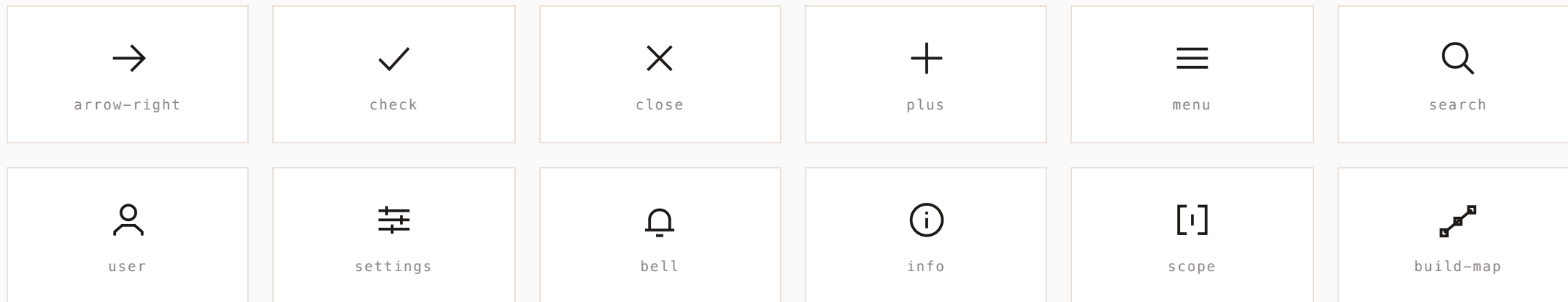
Start with direction

Full hierarchy available. The default surface for long-form.

Minimum sizes

Body never below 14px on a dark ground, 13px on light. Labels never below 11px, and never without the 0.18em tracking that makes them legible.

Angular by default. Curves only where a form is genuinely round.



CONSTRUCTION

24x24 viewBox. 1.5px stroke. Butt caps and miter joins for square-cut terminals. No fills. Geometry snapped to a 2px grid wherever the form allows.

Only the search lens and the info disc are round, because those forms genuinely are. Everything else stays angular so the set echoes the wedge instead of fighting it.

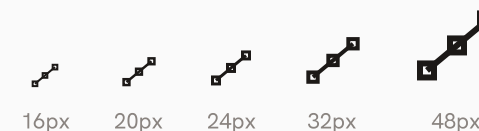
COLOUR

Icons are drawn with `stroke="currentColor"` and inherit the surrounding text colour. They never carry Action Red: red is commitment, and an icon is navigation.

BEYOND THIS SET

Lucide matches the stroke weight and terminal style most closely. Re-cap any borrowed icon to butt terminals before use.

SCALE — BUILD-MAP



Every glyph is checked at 18px before it ships. Three icons were redrawn in this edition because their detail closed into a blob at that size: settings, bell, and build-map.

DRAWING A NEW ICON

Start from an existing glyph

Copy the nearest icon in the set and edit it. Starting from a blank grid is how stroke weights and terminal styles drift apart.

Snap to the 2px grid

Coordinates land on even numbers or clean halves. Off-grid geometry renders soft at 16px and 24px.

Check it at 18px before shipping

If two elements sit closer than 3px they will close into a blob. Respace them rather than thinning the stroke.

Never fill, never colour

No solid shapes, no Action Red, no second weight. The set reads as one system because nothing in it is special.

Like a builder who has watched projects die in a repo.

HEADLINE	Stop putting your life's work off.
SUB-HEADLINE	Maker Compass turns a rough idea into the market context, first-version scope, mockups, and technical direction you need before you write code.
CTA BUTTON	Start with your idea
SECONDARY CTA	See how it works
ERROR STATE	That idea description came through empty. Add a sentence or two about what it does and who it is for, then run it again.
EMPTY STATE	No plans yet. Start with one idea, even a rough one.
LOADING	Reading the market around your idea.
SOCIAL POST	Generation is cheap now. Judgment is not. That gap is where most ideas quietly die.

ADJECTIVES

Quietly direct. Anti-hype. Specific. Constructively critical.

RULES

- Short sentences, plain verbs.
- Say "first version" more than "MVP".
- No em dashes: commas, colons, semicolons, periods, parentheses.
- Lead with the next action.
- Never promise instant startups or effortless success.

WORDS WE NEVER USE

unlock, supercharge, revolutionize, 10x, powered by AI, seamless, effortless, game-changing, elevate, curated, premium, cutting-edge, "in today's fast-paced world"

A tagline test: if it could appear on any other tool's homepage without anyone noticing, it is not finished.

HOW THE REGISTER SHIFTS

Marketing

Makes a claim and defends it. Shortest sentences in the system. This is the only place the brand argues with the category.

Product

Names the artifact and the next decision. No persuasion: the user already committed. Warm, factual, never chatty.

Errors and empty states

Says what happened, then what to do. Two sentences maximum. Never blames the user, never apologises at length.

Long-form output

PRDs, competitive reads, tech specs. Same craft as the marketing copy: in this product the artifact is the deliverable.

Found, not staged.



EXEMPLARY FRAME — REAL LIGHT, REAL ROOM, QUIET COMPOSITION

SUBJECT	Evidence of thinking in progress: paper with hand-drawn wireframes, index cards in columns, pinned cards, kraft folders. Closed laptops as often as open ones.
LIGHT	Real light only. Window light, overcast daylight, low late-afternoon rake. Never studio strobes.
COLOUR	Warm neutrals, with exactly one red object in frame and nothing else red.
CAST	Diverse across any set. Name a specific ethnicity per prompt; the model default skews white. Vary body types and ages, not only skin tone.
TEXTURE	Film grain always. Rooms that have been used. Slight imperfections.
SCREENS	Grey placeholder rectangles and at most one red rectangle. No readable interface text; brand text is composited later so it stays editable.

NEVER IN THE PROMPT

studio strobes, softbox, "professional", "premium", modern office, coworking space, glass partitions, "startup vibes", neon, holograms, clean white background, lens flare

BANNED CLICHÉ CONCEPTS

lightbulbs, hourglasses, handshakes, network nodes, glowing brains, rockets, mazes, puzzle pieces, humanoid AI figures, a literal compass held up to the lens

Never name a real publication or person: it is the fastest route to baked-in text and a moderation refusal.

COMPOSITING OVER GENERATION

Generate the surface blank

Ask for an empty screen, sticker, or panel. Naming a logo in the prompt returns garbled pseudo-text and wrong-weight letterforms every time.

Composite the artwork after

Perspective-map the real asset onto the surface. build-composites.py detects the quad and warps the artwork onto it.

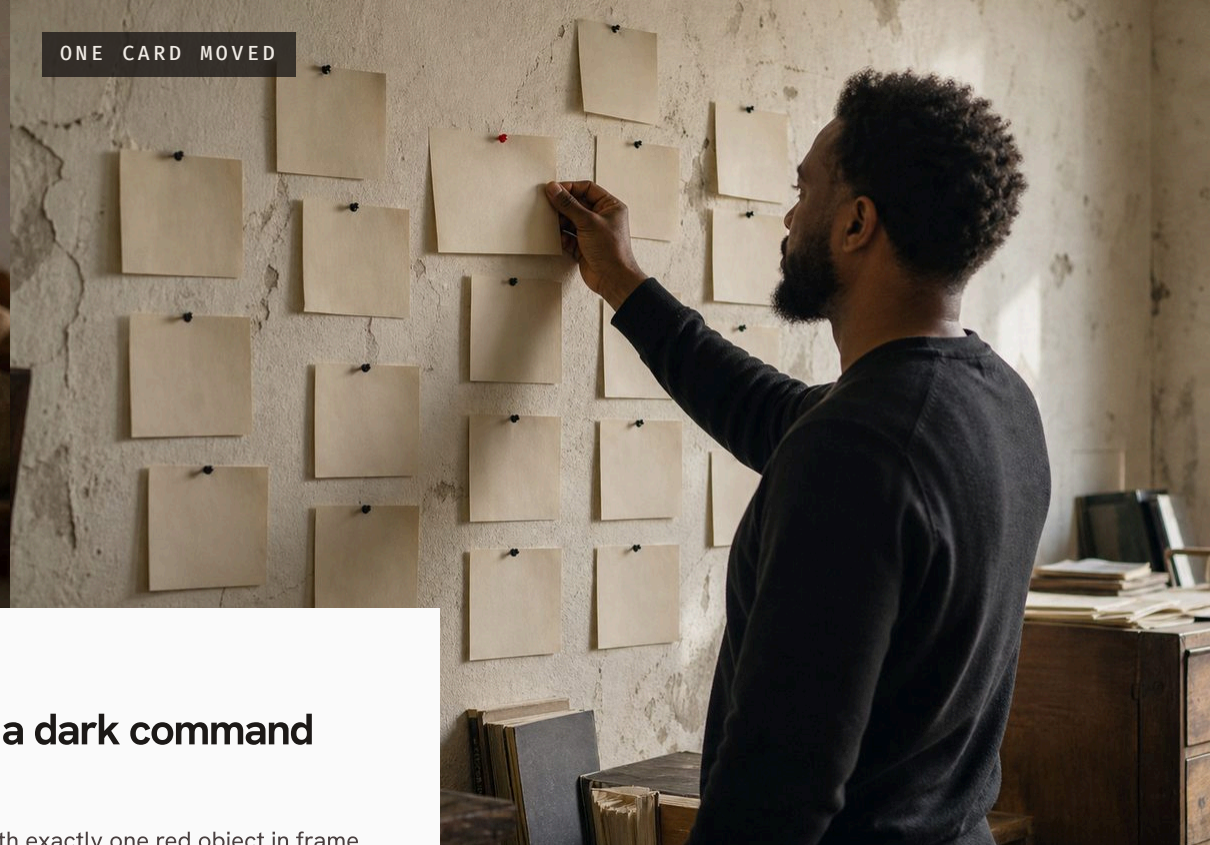
Why it matters

The mark stays correctly typeset, the copy stays editable, and the shot can be regenerated when the wordmark or palette changes.

SORTING SCOPE



ONE CARD MOVED



VISUAL WORLD

A lit workshop, not a dark command center.

Real light only. Warm neutrals with exactly one red object in frame.
Film grain always. Subjects work, they do not address the camera.
Cast is diverse by default, named per prompt.

Deliberately pre-digital: the thinking happens before the tooling.

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LAPTOP CLOSED

COMMITTED TO PAPER

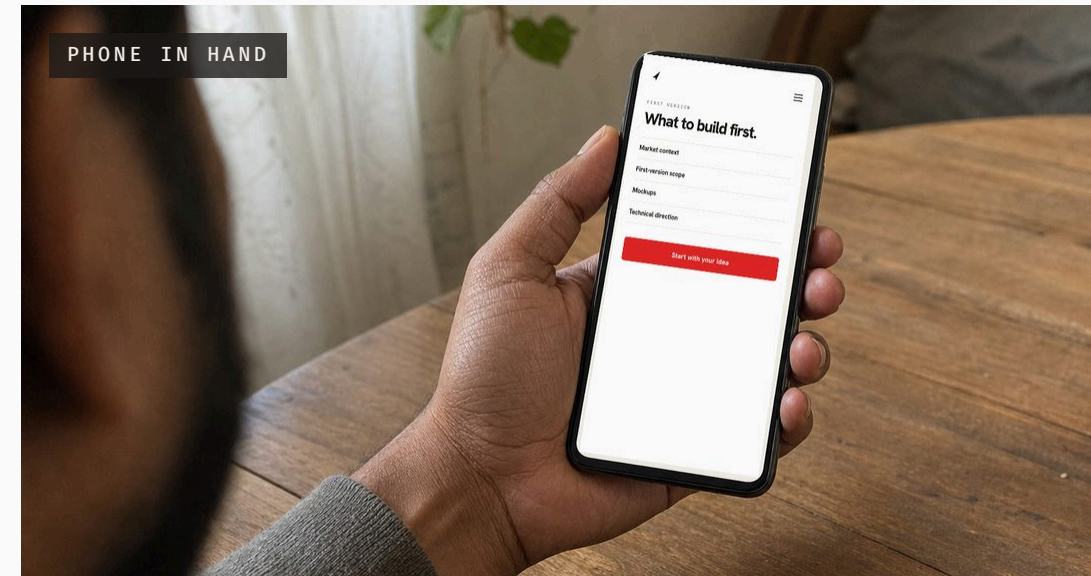


Where the identity meets the physical world.



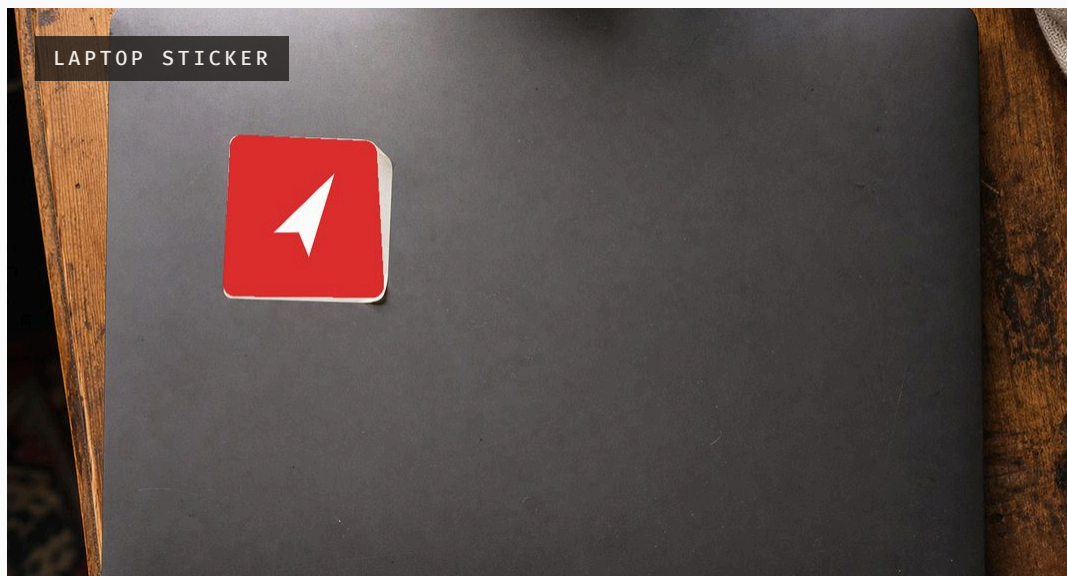
PRODUCT IN CONTEXT

Screens show real output, never invented UI.



PHONE IN HAND

Symbol alone in the mobile nav, never the full lockup.



LAPTOP STICKER

White symbol on Action Red. Die-cut square, 50mm.



CANVAS TOTE

Stacked lockup, single-colour screen print, 180mm wide.

Specs for the secondary set.

 **MakerCompass**

Priya Raman

Founder

MAKERCOMPASS.COM

BUSINESS CARD • 85 × 55MM

Uncoated warm stock, 400gsm. Lockup at 34mm wide, one cap height from the trim.



AVATAR APP ICON

Symbol only, never the wordmark. Ship the asset with sharp corners; the platform applies its own rounding.

 **Priya Raman**
Founder, Maker Compass

EMAIL SIGNATURE

Symbol at 26px, no image-heavy banner, no quote.

 **MakerCompass**

**Direction first.
Then build.**

Q3 REVIEW • 2026

PRESENTATION COVER • 16:9

Workshop Black ground, stacked lockup top-left, one idea per slide. Never a gradient, never a stock photo behind the title.



WORKSPACE

Priya's reading app

Scope it

Open plan

PRODUCT CHROME • NAVIGATION RAIL

Symbol alone on Workshop Black, never the lockup. 8px rounding inside the product, sharp corners on landing surfaces.

 **MakerCompass**

**Generation is cheap now.
Judgment is not.**

SOCIAL SHARE CARD • 1200 × 630

One claim, one red rule, lockup top-left. No photography behind the type; the claim has to carry it alone.

PRODUCTION SPECS

Favicon

32px and 16px exports of the simplified silhouette. Never scale a large PNG down; the notch turns to mud.

Sticker

50mm die-cut square, white symbol on Action Red, matte laminate, 1.5mm white keyline.

Tote

Stacked lockup, single-colour screen print in Workshop Black, 180mm wide, centred on the front panel.

Print colour

No Pantone matched yet. Get Action Red matched physically against uncoated stock before any run.

The grid is typographic, not photographic.

 HOW IT WORKS Start with your idea

BEFORE YOU BUILD

Stop putting your life's work off.

Give it the rough idea. Get back the market context, the first version worth building, and where to start.

WEBSITE HERO

Sharp corners on landing surfaces, 8px rounding inside the product. Red on exactly one element. Tinted-white ground, never flat #FFF. Entrance motion uses cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1) with no bounce.

Generation is cheap now.



The start is the hard part.

Judgment is not.

MakerCompass

Direction beats momentum theater.

First version, not MVP.



Random features create motion, not progress.

INSTAGRAM GRID

Type and colour carry the feed. Photography appears at most once per row, never as a filler tile. Captions run in the same voice as the product: one claim, no hashtags, no emoji.



The start is the hard part.

MAKERCOMPASS.COM

STORY TEMPLATE

Symbol top-left, claim bottom-left, one red rule. Safe margin 16px. Link-in-bio uses the same ground with stacked text rows and no icons.

CHANNEL RULES

One claim per post

No threads unless asked. No hashtags, no emoji, no rocket. If the post needs a hook to work, the claim is not strong enough.

Photography is rationed

At most one photo per grid row. A photo used as a filler tile is the fastest way to look like every other tool.

Red marks the ask

Exactly one red element per composition, and it is always the thing you want clicked. Never a decorative red tile.

Motion

cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1), 550ms for entrances, 200ms for state. No bounce, no spring, no parallax.

The five that actually get broken.

DO

- ✓ Leave one full cap height of clear space around the lockup, including in social crops.
- ✓ Let one element dominate every composition. Flat hierarchy is the tell of an undesigned page.
- ✓ Name the artifact ("your first-version scope", "the competitive read"), not the feature.
- ✓ Use Fira Mono uppercase at 0.18em for every kicker and metadata line, and nothing else.
- ✓ Show the product's real output, including when it is long and unglamorous.

DON'T

- ✗ Don't put Action Red on more than 10% of a screen, or on two unrelated elements at once.
- ✗ Don't use red for errors or focus rings. Errors are #C0392B; focus rings are #4A4040.
- ✗ Don't set display type at flat tracking. -0.05em, or it reads as a wireframe.
- ✗ Don't imply the product writes the app for you. It decides what the app should be.
- ✗ Don't ship a gradient hero, a glass panel, a sparkle, or a "Powered by AI" badge.

THE ANTI-GENERIC TEST

Before anything ships, ask whether it could be the brand for literally anything else. If yes, it is not done. A strong brand is a specific product plus a clear audience model plus a point of view. The restraint in this document is not a taste preference: a tool that sells direction cannot ship a hype-styled interface, so the argument dies with any one of those don'ts.

REGENERATING

```
build-symbol.py
build-wordmark.py
build-icons.py
build-tokens.py
build-book.py
```

In that order. Tokens derive from DESIGN.json, so the kit cannot drift from what the product ships.